

Quiet Mission

No insider insights as this gentleman diplomat remembers



WORDS WORDS WORDS:
ADVENTURES IN DIPLOMACY
by T.P. SREENIVASAN
Pearson Longman
Price: Rs 600; Pages: 253

■ By Amitabh Mattoo

The term 'candid and honest diplomat' appears to be an oxymoron. After all, diplomacy is the art of being discreet and lying for your country. Post-retirement, however, many diplomats suddenly seem to turn cathartic, finally giving vent to long-suppressed opinions. Diplomatic memoirs the world over often border on the scandalous. This, however, is not the case with Ambassador Sreenivasan and *Words Words Words: Adventures in Diplomacy*. Sreenivasan appears to have been a gentleman diplomat, a rare breed. And this is a gentleman's book. No major scandals, no great revelations, but an interesting read nonetheless. The initial pages are devoted to encapsulating the author's life, from his childhood in Kayamkulam in Kerala to his retirement as India's ambassador to the IAEA in Vienna. The rest of the book deals with the challenges Sreenivasan faced during his career. As he points out: "Two military coups, two expulsions and two broken limbs in an armed attack are not the stuff that diplomatic dreams are made of. But there was abundant recompense for them in the 37 years in the IES. I walked in and out of the White House and the Kremlin, worked in the United Nations, broke bread with the high and the mighty, encountered celebrities, presented credentials to more than 10 heads of state and spoke for a billion people for India on a variety of issues."

The chapter "Nuclear Winter, Kargil Spring", which deals with Indo-US relations in the wake of the 1998 nuclear tests, is insightful. The author played a significant role in mending relations with the US Congress. One wishes, however, that Sreenivasan was more expansive with his "insider" knowledge on men and matters. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
2. (9)	Playing for Pizza	John Grisham	Random House
3. (5)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
4. (6)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Penguin
5. (2)	The Last Testament	Sam Bourne	HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (9)	Buddha: A Story of Enlightenment	Deepak Chopra	HarperCollins
3. (12)	Romancing With Life: An Autobiography	Dev Anand	Penguin
4. (16)	The Age of Turbulence	Alan Greenspan	Penguin
5. (6)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
9. (3)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
13. (-)	Animal's People	Indra Sinha	Penguin
18. (-)	Above Average	Amitabha Bagchi	HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	Mr & Mrs Dutt	Priya Dutt	Roli Books
7. (4)	King of Bollywood: Shah Rukh Khan	Anupama Chopra	Warner Brothers
8. (-)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cellphone: Reflections on India in the 21st Century	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
10. (5)	The Kao boys of R & AW	B. Raman	Lancer

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead